CHAPTER ONE

# Antisemitism in the Age of Jewish Empowerment

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## INTRODUCTION

The fact that antisemitism continues to exercise such an agonizing hold upon the collective imagination of Jewish communities today stems as much from the memories of the past as the experiences of the present. At the level of pure emotion, it seems inconceivable, less than a century after the Holocaust, that Jews should once again face mass violence, or be subjected to the kinds of wild calumnies that afflicted those generations who lived prior to 1945. Hence, there is an understandable tendency to filter reports of present-day episodes—a baying mob assaulting a synagogue in Paris,[1] a series of bricks lobbed through the windows of a Dutch rabbi's home[2]—through the images and narratives accumulated by Jewish history. Consequently, an attack on a Jewish individual or institution never seems like an isolated instance, but another link in a chain without end, defying understanding and thereby fueling the common description of antisemitism as "irrational"—a word that is simultaneously comforting and devoid of meaningful insight.

These acute Jewish sensitivities are exacerbated by two factors. Firstly, the awareness that antisemitism is truly an international phenomenon, manifesting in countries as culturally different as, for example, Venezuela and Iran, yet incorporating similar thematic obsessions in both. The ease with which antisemitic sentiment in different locations can be instantly publicized and shared, by uploading texts, still images, and videos onto social media platforms, merely bolsters this sense of a threat that is immediate and global.

Secondly, there is the discursive aspect of today's antisemitism, which frequently strikes at Jewish collective memory through word and picture associations. Most of the time, the target is Israel, the Jewish state whose nature and actions are analogized to villains both historic (such as Nazi Germany, or the former apartheid regime in South Africa) and current (like the "Islamic

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